

GOWN AND PETTICOAT SACK BACK DRESS

The sack back dress, also known as a *robe à la française*, started out as an informal style in France earlier in the 18th century. It came to be the most elegant dress for most of the mid-century throughout Europe and the fashionable world. The sack back could be worn in two ways. The pleats could hang straight down from the back of the shoulders into a slight train. In the alternative polonaise style, the back fabric was tucked up using tapes in the waistband to create fullness at the back. The dress was cut away at the front, and so would have been worn with a triangular stomacher, as well as a matching petticoat. A pair of stays worn under the dress kept the bodice rigid and flat fronted and moulded the body into the fashionable cone shape, with a narrow waist widening to the bust.



BACK VIEW WITH SKIRT DOWN



SIDE VIEW WITH SKIRT DOWN



Dress is cut away (open) at the front

Stomachers were often beautifully embroidered

The robe is worn open to reveal the petticoat

Heavily pleated petticoat